A Race Against Time:
The Partition of India (1947)

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Letter from the Chair

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to SASMUN VIII! My name is Divya Bhatia and I am a junior from New Jersey. I have been involved with Model UN since my freshman year, serving as a delegate, a vice-chair, and now a chair. I am incredibly honored to be chairing the *A Race Against Time: The Partition of India (1947)* crisis committee. In addition to myself, the dais will include Olivia Ike and Dashiell Guariglia as our vice-chair and as our crisis director respectively. The goal of our dais is to ensure a successful and educational experience so we will be assisting you with any help needed leading up to SASMUN.

During this committee, you will face one of the most volatile and defining moments in modern history – the collapse of British colonial rule in South Asia and the birth of two nations. This committee will explore political division, religious conflict, and the human toll of hurried independence. With communal violence increasing rapidly, border uncertainty, and leadership fractures, your decisions will shape the future of a region on the brink. Expect sudden assassinations, mass uprisings, and press leaks. Nothing is off the table.

This committee is designed for delegates ready to think on their feet, navigate shifting alliances, and make high stake decisions under pressure and time constraints. I hope you approach this crisis with historical curiosity, empathy, and creativity.

If you have any questions, please feel free to reach out in advance to the conference. I can't wait to see where you all take this crisis!

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Introduction to the Crisis

On August 15, 1947, the British Raj officially ended, and two new nations were born, India and Pakistan. Yet the months leading up to this moment were filled with violence, fear, and instability. What was imagined to be a peaceful transfer of power rapidly became bloodshed. This committee will begin in mid-1947, with the chaos sending ripples across the subcontinent. Please note that you will be expected to have no knowledge of how this event actually unfolded in real time.

As the British scramble to finalize their withdrawal, the Indian National Congress and the All-India Muslim League battle over territory, ideals, and the future of South Asia. In the background, states hesitate to commit to a side, religious tensions explode, and millions of civilians begin to flee their homes in anticipation of shifting borders. The situation demands swift and decisive leadership as the people are at a crossroads.

You will determine how the future of these two countries plays out. This committee places you at the heart of a global turning point. Whether you hold power, challenge it, or seek to survive it, your choices will determine the lives of future generations.

History of Topic

In India, followed by the Indian Rebellion in 1857, British colonial rule officially began in 1858. However before that, British influence across commercial, military, and political fields, had been growing for over a century, primarily through the East India Company. The East India Company is an English, joint-stock company that began as a commercial venture to control spice trade. The company later on evolved into a powerful and military force to rule India. Over time, Indians' resentment and resistance grew towards the British, leading to a nationwide independence movement.

In the early 20th century, the Indian National Congress emerged as a key powerful drive for Indian nationalism to rise. The Indian National Congress (INC) was a political party in India which began the first modern nationalist movement to rise during the British Empire. eventually led India to its independence. Mahatma Gandhi and other crucial figures promoted non-violent approaches towards resisting British Rule. On the other hand, the All-India Muslim League, under the leadership of Muhammad Ali Jinnah, grew increasingly concerned about Muslim representation and rights in a Hindu-majority India.

During the 1940s, tensions began to escalate rapidly. The Quit India Movement, a massive protest movement against the British Raj's control, was a non-violent way to fight for the rights of Indians, proposed by Mahatma Gandhi and followers of the Indian National Congress. However, this movement included mass arrests of Congress leaders, all while communal violence rapidly increased. In 1946, the Cabinet Mission attempted to come to a compromise between the INC and the Muslim League, but ultimately failed due to a lack of trust. Later the same year, the Muslim League called for a Direct Action Day, which led to horrific riots in Calcutta with widespread killings between Hindus and Muslims. Similar outbreaks followed in Bihar and Punjab.

In February of 1947, British Prime Minister Clement Attlee announced that Britain's departure from India would be by June 1948. However, Lord Louis Mountbatten, who was appointed Viceroy, quickly sped up the timeline by over a year, making Britain's departure August 1947. As a result, the Radcliffe Line, the international border of India and Pakistan, was drawn in just five weeks.

The result of the Radcliffe Line was destructive. Over 15 million people were displaced, forced to migrate on the basis of religion. As estimated 2 million people lost lives in the chaos. Trains of refugees arrived massacred, villages destroyed and ultimately, families torn apart.

This committee will begin just as the partition plan is being finalized – but with everything still in flux. Will you stabilize the situation or make it worse?

Member Positions

Jawaharlal Nehru
Leader of the Indian nationalist movement and India's first prime minister to-be.
Nehru envisions a modern, self-reliant India that is free from the British. Nehru initially is opposed to the idea of partitioning India but later on agrees to it as a way to become independent of Britain.

Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel
An Indian political leader who served as the first Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister of India, earning him the nickname "Iron Man of India". Patel is a practical leader tasked with keeping order and overseeing the division of states between India and Pakistan. His approach is often blunt, favoring security over compromise.

Abul Kalam Azad
A senior Muslim leader within the INC, Azad is a firm believer in Hindu-Muslim unity. He sees partition as a disaster for India's future and works to embrace both Hindus and Muslims in a united India.

B.R. Ambedkar
An Indian social reformer and principal architect of the Constitution of India, Ambedkar is a strong advocate of the rights of the Dalits (formerly untouchables) and the marginalized. Ambedkar does not support the formation of Pakistan but he does believe that the partition is inevitable.

Muhammad Ali Jinnah
Founder to-be of Pakistan and leader of the Muslim League, Jinnah believes Muslims cannot live safely in a Hindu-majority India. He is incredibly determined to develop Pakistan, though his health is failing.

Liaquat Ali Khan
Jinnah's right hand man and political strategist. Liaquat is instrumental in shaping Pakistan's future government and is a key negotiator for the Muslim League during the tensions of the Partition.

Khawaja Nazmuddin
A Bengali leader in the Muslim League who represents the voice of Muslims in Bengal and East Pakistan. He builds on the League's claim to expand Muslim representation across the continent.

Master Tara Singh
Master Tara Singh was a prominent Sikh political leader who represented Sikh interests in Punjab in regards to the Partition. Fiercely opposed to division of Sikh-majority areas, he demands protection amid the chaos induced by the Partition.

Sardar Baldev Singh
The first Defence Minister of India and a Sikh leader allied with the Congress. Baldev Singh must balance his role in national politics with the needs of the Sikh community in Punjab.

Maharaja Hari Singh (Kashmir)
The Hindu ruler of Kashmir, Maharaja Hari Singh is under pressure to choose between India and Pakistan. His indecision risks making Kashmir the epicenter of **future** conflict.

Mir Osman Ali Khan (Hyderabad)
The wealthy Nizam of Hyderabad. He seeks to remain an independent state rather than accede to either India or Pakistan, but face internal unrest and external pressure.

Lord Louis Mountbatten
The last Viceroy of India, Mountbatten is tasked with overseeing the transfer of power. His decisions determine the pacing of independence, the success of negotiations, and the fate of millions.

Sir Cyril Radcliffe
A British lawyer tasked with dividing British India into India and Pakistan. Radcliffe has the impossible task of drawing a border for partition in only five weeks, with little knowledge of India.

Sir Evan Jenkins
Governor of Punjab, one of the most volatile regions during the partition. Jenkins must manage communal violence and collapsing order in Punjab, most affected by the Radcliffe Line.

Mahatma Gandhi
The spiritual and moral leader of India's independence movement. Gandhi strongly opposes partition and uses non-violence to try to sway events. Though lacking official political power, his influence is unmatached.

Goals of the Committee

This committee is designed to simulate the intensity of a collapsing empire, the rise of new nations, and the challenge of preventing a civil war. Your goal will be to situate yourselves in mid-1947 where tensions are at the max and ensure future generations do not suffer from your decisions. You will be negotiating the terms of the Partition, preventing and responding to communal violence, and managing humanitarian collapse. You will also respond to assassinations, uprisings, and foreign influence. The dais encourages the committee members to form directives, forge alliances, issue press releases, and send private notes as you try to guide your character's agenda. There is no fixed outcome as everything is in play.

Closing Remarks

As nations across the world continue to suffer with the aftermath of British colonialism, the lessons of 1947 remain deeply relevant. The Partition of India was not only a moment of independence but also a moment of fracture, where human ambition, fear, and ideology collided in ways that reshaped the global order.

In this committee, you are tasked with navigating dilemmas of unity or division, peace or violence, compromise or tyranny. Every directive and every alliance will have consequences, some immediate and other echoing far into the future. Your challenge is not to simply win arguments, but to shape a path forward in one of the most fragile and decision transitions of the 20th century.

We, as your dias, hope you approach this committee with creativity, empathy, and resolve. The choices you make will not only rewrite history but also reveal the challenges leaders face today, when confronted with division, nationalism, and humanitarian crisis.

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